

A field guide to free, private AI on your own computer

Free ChatGPT.

Set up Open WebUI in under 10 minutes — a free, private, unlimited ChatGPT-style app that runs on your own machine. No subscription, no data leaving your computer.

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READ TIME

4 minutes

The Problem

ChatGPT, Claude Pro, Midjourney, Perplexity — stack a few subscriptions and you're at \$80–100 a month before doing anything real. And every chat you type goes to someone else's server: client info, business plans, half-baked ideas, all living somewhere you don't control.

THE FIX

Ollama runs the AI model on your computer. Open WebUI is the chat window that talks to it. Together: ChatGPT, but free, private, and 100% offline once it's running.

What You Get

A familiar chat interface, document chat (drop in a PDF and ask questions), image generation, voice input, multi-model switching, multi-user accounts, and full offline use once installed.

The Setup, Step by Step

1

Install Ollama

Download from ollama.com and run it like any other app — this is the engine that runs the model.

2

Pull a model

Open Terminal/PowerShell and download the AI brain.

```
ollama pull llama3
```

3 Install Open WebUI

One Docker command. If Docker isn't installed yet, grab Docker Desktop first, open it once, then run this.

```
docker run -d -p 3000:8080 --add-host=host.docker.internal:host-gateway -v open-webui:/app/backend/data --name open-webui --restart always ghcr.io/open-webui/open-webui:main
```

4 Open localhost:3000

Create your account — the first one becomes admin. You're now chatting with your own private AI.

Models to Try

llama3 *Great all-rounder*

Best first pick — solid for everyday questions, writing, brainstorming.

mistral *Fast, strong at writing*

Use when you want quick replies and clean prose.

codellama *Best for code*

If you write or debug code, this is your model.

gemma2 *Efficient on lower-end hardware*

Start here if your laptop is older or low on RAM.

Resources

Open WebUI *Free · openwebui.com*

Ollama *Free · ollama.com*

Docker Desktop *Free · docker.com*

Do This Today

- 01** Download and install Ollama.
 - 02** Pull llama3 in your terminal.
 - 03** Run the Docker command and open localhost:3000 to start chatting.
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